pell-mell to the locker room just minutes before the closing bell. In those days, all submissions were handwritten, there were no computers then, and we had a special ruled cardboard sheet called a Staff Duties (SD) card, which was placed below the main sheet of paper to get the alignment just right. It was a tedious and painstaking job to write out as many as thirty to forty pages on occasion, without a single mistake, cutting or overwriting. One mistake and that page had to be rewritten. Some officers, when hard-pressed for time, would get their wives to do the writing for them. One such officer got his corrected assignment back with the remark, 'Your wife's handwriting has improved.' Sometimes, we seniors feel that the officers have it easy now, with Microsoft Word and 'cut and paste' making staff work so much easier. I see no harm in that, if the time saved can be used for more productive activities, including spending time with your family, something we were hard-pressed for. All of us were in the same age bracket with two children each, so there would be a birthday party almost every week. That innocuous titbit of information to carry lots of birthday presents, which we had done, came in handy. The alternative would have been to buy gifts from the one and only local store, aptly named 'Needs' at exorbitant hill-station prices.

The cost of living in Wellington was high and it was difficult to make ends meet, with pay scales in those days being abysmally low. I had placed standing instructions from my bank in Pune to transfer a fixed sum to the bank in Wellington. By the end of the month, we used to be down to our last hundred rupees. Several officers had withdrawn money from their provident fund (PF) or had regular top-ups from their parents. We had a large number of guests throughout the year—parents, uncles and aunts, brothers and sisters, even my brother's friends—which added to the monthly expenses. We entertained them all

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